

Feast like a King

The silver *thaal*
of Santrampur Estate

The grand plated *thaal* (XL for thali) is perhaps the finest expression of India's epicurean luxury and culinary opulence. It is a multi-course meal laid out with all its pairings in a single serving of visual delight. Many eminent designers like Gunjan Gupta and Ayush Kasliwal have interpreted the traditional round plate and its bowls into contemporary expressions of lavishness yet nothing matches the imposing grandeur of the Santrampur Thaal—a mammoth 2-ft broad solid silver moulded plate that comes with its own legs in the shape of lion paws. A recreation of a more than a 100-year-old traditional *thaal*—used by Maharaja Joravar Singhji of the erstwhile Santrampur State in Mahisagar, Gujarat—the plate has grooves that hold 15 brass bowls of varying sizes for curries, salads and chutneys. In 2019, when Joravar Vilas—the majestic Santrampur palace on the banks of Harsiddhi lake—was converted into a boutique heritage hotel, Mandakini Kumari, the current maharani, decided to recreate the heirloom *thaal* for the guests to have a “royal dining experience on the table”. The fully hand-carved *thaal*, shaped like a Rajput palace window arch at the top, comes in both solid silver and silver-plated versions that are now made on order by Code Silver, a Jaipur-based design house. Priced at ₹5.4 lakh for the silver version and ₹36,000 for the silver-plated version, each *thaal* comes with a promise of a unique alchemy for its diner—to transform any food served on it into a royal repast.

